should bowl the full quota of fifty overs to us, even if we'd achieved the target. In fact, towards the end of the Natal innings we were all trying to give them some extra runs and Sourav kept close-in fielders in the ring to allow them to score freely, so that we would have a decent total to chase down. But in our reply we collapsed well before the fifty overs and the question of the opposition bowling the full quota never arose! We were all out for 158 and lost the match by 32 runs.

In both matches I had batted at number three, which was the result of a decision that had been taken soon after we had reached South Africa. There had been a meeting of the senior players and the coach, and most of my team-mates, including Sourav, Rahul and Srinath, felt I should bat at number three in the competition. Only Anil suggested that I should open. The majority argument was that at the top of the order I might get a good ball early on and get out, which would end up putting the team under pressure. After the second practice game John Wright came to my room and asked me if I was really happy batting in the number three position. I assured him that I would bat anywhere the team wanted me to. John, however, insisted that I should voice my personal opinion as a player, so I said that, if it were up to me, I would prefer to open. I went on to say that I felt I could control the game from that position, and I also told him that there was no guarantee anyway that I wouldn't get out early if I was batting at number three or four, as it only takes one good ball. So I thought my best opportunity to set up the match for India was as an opener. John agreed with me and finally convinced Sourav and the rest of the team that having me at the top of the order was our best option.

The pool games

The less-than-impressive performances in our warm-up matches had made the first pool match on 12 February 2003, against the Netherlands, extremely important. We had to start well to give ourselves a fighting chance in the tournament. Even if the Netherlands were not the best opposition in the world, they had some good players in their team who had experience of playing on the county circuit in England. As I went out to bat, I was unusually nervous. The expectations in India were huge and the dressing room was also expecting a lot from me, now that they'd agreed to my wish to open the batting. I'd caused our plans to be changed completely and now it was up to me to deliver.